



Key figure: Arguably one of the most gifted Indian midfielders in recent years, Ashique Kuruniyan (centre) proved his merit once again in the match between Mohun Bagan Super Giant and Kerala Blasters FC. PICS: FSDL

ASHIQUE'S DAY OUT

The **versatile midfielder** changed the complexion of the game despite arriving in the dying minutes.

Arriving in the 80th minute of the action and becoming the player of the match may sound extraordinary to a football aficionado.

But that is precisely what happened in the Indian Super League as Mohun Bagan Super Giant overhauled Kerala Blasters FC's challenge 3-2 with two goals in the final nine minutes.

Those tasked with determining the player of the match award had no doubt that it was Ashique Kuruniyan, the versatile midfielder who changed the complexion of the game despite arriving in the dying minutes of the action.

Ashique spent almost a year recovering from an ACL injury in his



knee, sustained in September 2023, to reclaim his place in the team (Mohun Bagan SG) and the esteem of head coach José Molina.

"It is a big fight out there, and we really have to work hard to secure a place in the side," said Ashique, who was presented to the media before Mohun Bagan's away match against NorthEast United FC.

The talented footballer spent much of his time on the bench, making brief appearances as a substitute. However, the real opportunity to return to the starting line-up came when Mohun Bagan saw two of its key defenders — Alberto Rodriguez and Subhasish Bose — suspended before the crucial match against NorthEast.

Molina entrusted Ashique with the task of manning the defence as a left-back. It was not his usual position, but he did his job with sincerity as Mohun Bagan emerged a 2-0 winner in Guwahati.

With Molina seemingly determined not to alter his chosen line-up, Mohun Bagan ran into serious trouble against